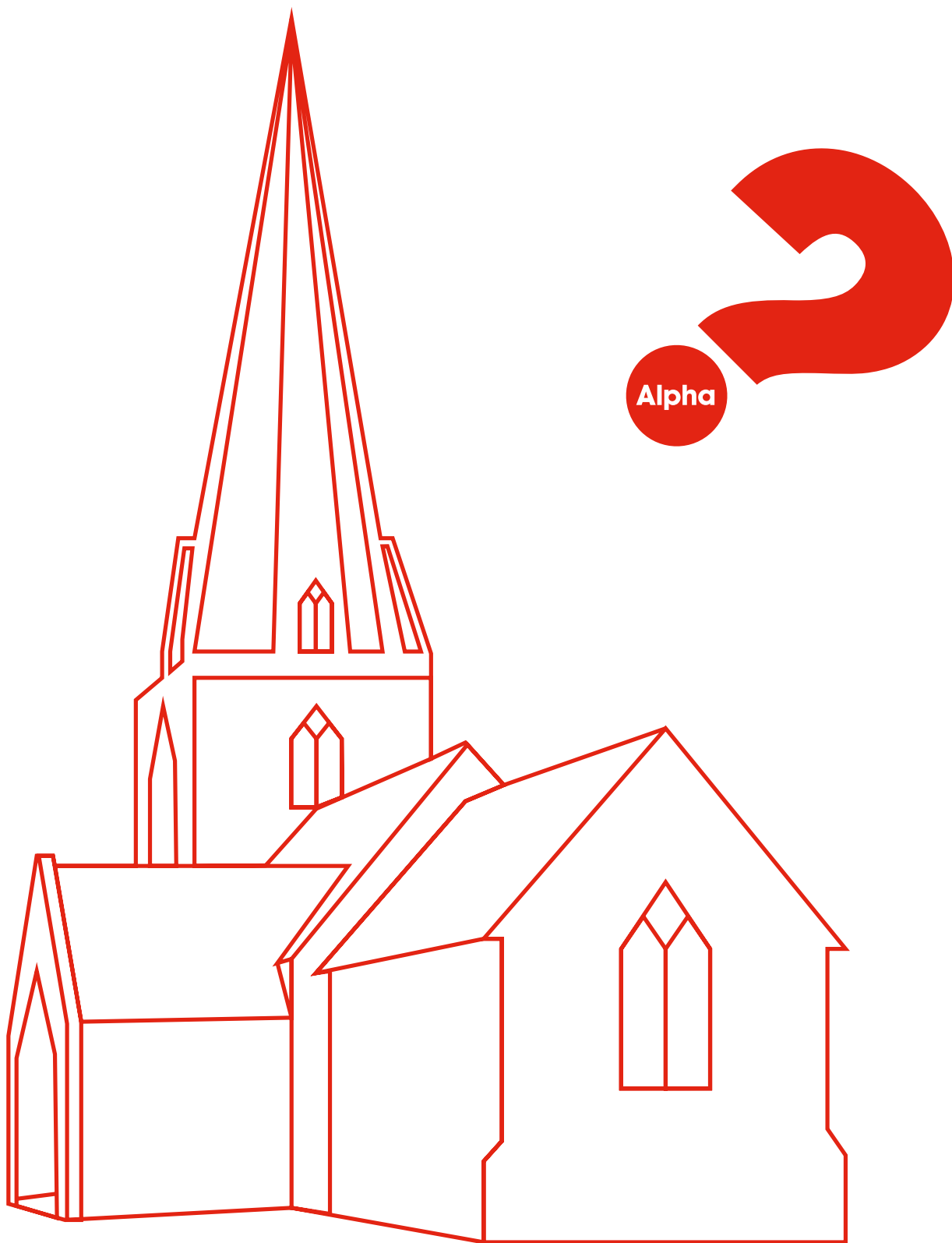




Alpha as a Church Planting Tool



Revd Nicky Gumbel
Vicar of HTB and Pioneer of Alpha

“Church planting is essential to church growth. This is something we at HTB learned from John Wimber and others in the 1980s and we can now speak from experience after planting around 30 churches in London and, in recent years, in some major cities around England.

The first thing our Church Planters have done on setting up in their new location has been to launch Alpha to enable people outside the church to hear about Jesus and join the community. I am so glad this booklet has been written to help every Church Planter to see how Alpha might have a place in their vision.”

Alpha as a Church Planting Tool



Every church has a story.

Whether your church has been meeting for a few hundred years or just a few days, there is a story of why and how that particular local family of Christian people came into existence. That story will include prayer, mission, Christian community and it might include Alpha.

Your church probably began with just a few people and a vision to grow and connect with the local community. Great cathedrals, small house churches and the gospel hall on the street corner all started because Christian people reached out in mission to their friends and the local community.

There is no surprise that Alpha is a great tool for church planters. Every church planter is looking for simple and effective ways for their team to connect the message of Jesus with the local community.

Alpha and church planting sit well together because they share the same values of mission, hospitality, raising leaders, building community and loving the local church.

Alpha is a flexible tool that makes it easy for any church to offer people a way to explore the basics of the Christian faith.

If you are looking for an easy and effective way to do mission – and all Church Planters are – Alpha is a great place to start.

Church Planters are sometimes young and often new to leadership. Starting a new church can be a daunting and complicated process. Alpha offers a tried and tested place to start — an immediate way to connect with people as plans and strategy are being formulated.

Alpha helps the Church Planter, and their team, to begin with the most important thing: mission. By running Alpha, and sitting in a small group with guests, you'll quickly discover the thoughts of local people and the needs of the community.

We hope this short guide will encourage you with some ideas for how Alpha can be your church planting tool.

What is Alpha?

“Alpha combines attractional and missional to become a nuclear engine for church planting. Alpha’s simple model of a meal, conversation and unique teaching style is the discipleship activator for so many of the church planting stories I know. Alpha can release a region in mission through an unprecedented trust factor given by nearly every global denomination.”

Revd Graham Singh
Executive Director
Church Planting Canada



Alpha is an Idea

What if there was a space where people could come to talk about the questions they carry? A place to discuss issues of life, faith and God in a welcoming environment. We believe that everyone should have the chance to explore the Christian faith, ask questions and share their point of view; wherever they are in the world.

Alpha is a Story

Alpha began in 1977 at Holy Trinity Brompton, an Anglican Church in London, as a course for people new to the Christian faith. In 1990, Nicky Gumbel took on Alpha and shifted the focus towards people who are not part of any church. Since then churches across the globe have used Alpha in churches, schools, universities, prisons, cafes, pubs, restaurants and homes to invite their friends to explore life, faith and God together.

Alpha is a Tool

Alpha is a flexible tool that makes it easy for anyone to explore the basics of the Christian faith. It has a structure that is tried and tested to create spaces for conversation, teaching and community which are welcoming, relaxed and low pressure for those not normally in church. It is made up of 15 sessions usually covered over 10 or 11 weeks including a weekend or day away. The sessions include social time centred around food, a short talk introducing an aspect of the Christian faith and a time of open discussion and questions together.

Alpha is a series of interactive sessions designed to help people explore the basics of the Christian faith.

No pressure.

No follow up.

No charge.

Why is **Alpha** Good for Church Planters?

Both in the UK and globally, church planting is a major way people come to faith, particularly those otherwise furthest from the church.

Planting a church is both an incredibly exciting adventure and a uniquely challenging undertaking. Church Planters are in the business of creating a space for community and mission but often face the challenges of limited resources, squeezed schedules, small teams and often struggles with limited or non-existent buildings.

Alpha provides both the structure and the flexibility to be a great solution to many of these challenges.

Alpha Creates Time

Alpha is really easy to run. It can be run anywhere, all it takes is good food, a talk and hosting a discussion. The weekend or day away requires a little bit more effort but is flexible enough to be easy to put on without a big cost or too much organisation. Whilst Alpha can be run for hundreds of people in one venue, it works equally well when run on a small scale in a home or coffee shop; many churches run concurrent small Alphas to reduce the complexity of administration.

Church Planters tend to be short on time, so having a flexible tool that allows you to do mission out of the box makes all the difference. Alpha can be run using live talks, but we also have several options of videos including the Alpha Film Series, a documentary style video series that makes it even easier to run Alpha anywhere.



Alpha Creates New Believers

The hope of most Church Planters is to introduce new people to faith in Jesus and then disciple them. Alpha is a great way to introduce people to the Christian faith in a way that naturally leads into whatever discipleship structure a church is using. Alpha has been incredibly effective in helping people get to the point of either becoming a believer or wanting to keep finding out more and come along to church.

Many churches have a small groups system and Alpha leads perfectly into gathering groups of believers to continue discussing

and delving into what it means to live out the Christian faith.

Alpha Creates Leaders

Church Planters are looking for effective ways to train leaders.

By running Alpha several times a year, perhaps once a term, you create a really simple pipeline for training leaders. First someone comes as a guest and comes to faith, then they come back and help in another Alpha group where they get to observe good leadership and gain some understanding of what it is like leading a group.

Then, once you feel they are ready, they can host a group. Eventually they may well find that they have an opportunity to run Alpha for a particular group they are involved in. One leader recently told us:

“There’s a girl who was in our Alpha group last term, she has joined our Connect Group and she is helping on Alpha this term. She is already talking about how she could find a way to run Alpha at work—she sees that her friends are facing lots of difficult life questions and she wants to find a way to share her new faith with them.”

Alpha provides a natural pipeline for creating new leaders in the church.

Alpha is Repeatable, Multipliable, Adaptable

Alpha can be run again and again both as a tool for evangelisation and as a pipeline for new leaders, which then gives a huge opportunity for sustainable church growth.

It may be that you start by running Alpha in your home. Then once you’ve got a few more leaders you might expand to run Alpha in a few homes and then send some leaders to run Alpha in various locations in schools, universities, workplaces, and cafes.

The idea is that Alpha works really well in a whole variety of contexts and so whatever your particular mission field looks like, you can adapt it to work for the people you want to reach.

“I run a small Connect Group at my church entirely made up of people who have done Alpha in the last couple of years. Some came to faith on Alpha, some shortly after, a couple still aren’t sure! We now have a community of people we are discipling who have come through Alpha. It just leads so naturally into being part of a community that share life together.”

Joseph, London



Story: Chris Sayburn

I didn't ever think I'd ever be a Christian let alone a vicar! As I was coming to the end of my ordination training, we were asked to be part of a new church plant at St Philip's Salford in Greater Manchester. There were big challenges in leaving our home and uprooting the family, but we were sure that God was calling us there.

As a church planting team we had loads of ideas of things we could do.

We wanted to do a few things well. We decided to focus on Sundays and Alpha.

In my last church, Alpha had proved to be a massively valuable resource. It's contextual, easy to use and it shares who Jesus is in such an accessible way. When people hear the gospel through coming on Alpha they can't fail to be changed by it.

The experience of running Alpha at St Philip's as a new church plant is hugely different from how I have run Alpha before. This is Alpha on a shoestring! Our entertainment might just be someone playing a piano at the front of the room. When the guests walk in, there might not be a three course meal but

we use the same principles, the same strength of welcome and well-trained small group hosts.



The new Alpha Film Series resource has been quite incredible, especially for the early days of our plant.

To know that all the resources are online, are of immense quality and are free is such a relief! Previously, I would spend lots of time preparing a live talk, but the Alpha Film Series has allowed me to put my focus into giving people a brilliant welcome and building and training my new team.

I passionately believe that Alpha is undersold as a tool for raising up leaders. Starting a new church plant has allowed us to take risks on a new team.

Sometimes people say, "I can't be a leader on Alpha because I don't have all the answers." If you have the humility to listen and learn from others, you are exactly who I want as a leader on my team.

Alpha has helped us to think differently about how we do mission.

The beauty of Alpha is that it can be run with three people on a sofa in someone's living room — it's not limited to a big venue. Alpha spearheads our culture of invitation and essentially we want one of two things from people; if you don't know Jesus, come to Alpha; if you do know Jesus, who are you bringing to Alpha and where are you serving?

The idea of building community, eating together, listening together and discussing together will remain the same and that is why Alpha is at the core of our church plant.

In September 2016, Revd Chris Sayburn was sent from St George's Leeds to be the Curate at St Philip's Salford in Greater Manchester.

Story: Olly Ryder

In 2015 I was invited to consider planting a Resource Church in Plymouth. As I was doing my daily Bible reading, I was drawn to Proverbs 18:10 which says *“The name of the Lord is a strong tower.”* I’d read it many times before but this time it was different, it leapt straight off the page and spoke to me in a different way.

My wife and I had a lot of questions about moving to Plymouth, so we did what most people do when they have big life questions... we turned to Wikipedia! As we glanced across the webpage we were drawn to the right hand side. There in Latin was the motto of the city: *Turris fortissima est nomen Jehova* (“The name of the Lord is a strong tower”). At that moment, we knew that God was asking us to consider this invitation seriously.

The more we learnt about Plymouth the more we got excited about it. We felt this was an amazing opportunity.

In September 2016 we planted in St Matthias Church, Plymouth. It’s a city of 250,00 people, 35,000 of them students. Just 1% of the city’s population attend an Anglican church; 2% any other.

To begin with we decided that we’d just focus on three things: Sunday morning, Sunday evening and Alpha. We wanted everyone we came into contact with to either help on Alpha or come on Alpha.



We focused everything on getting a great course up and running. If people wanted to start a home group we said, “Come on Alpha.” If they wanted to help with homeless work we said, “Come on Alpha.” If they wanted to do anything, we said, “Come on Alpha!”.

At our first Alpha, we had 12 groups with 120 people in total. It created a sense of community very quickly.

Other than Sunday services Alpha was the main thing that kickstarted the church.

I’ve run Alpha for more than 15 years and for many of these I’ve given the talks live.

However, we had so much on our plate getting the church up and running that it was fantastic to be able to download the Alpha Film Series for free and use that. The content is absolutely phenomenal with so many stories and interviews from all around the world. Everyone loved it! And it’s beautifully filmed.

Without doubt Alpha is the church planter’s dream.

Over 10 weeks, you take a group of people on a journey through all the foundational aspects of the Christian life. It also contains all the elements we wanted for our church going forward — a warm welcome, great hospitality, love, respect, fun, a vibrant experiential Christian life and a continuous culture of invitation and looking out to others.

Our dream is to be a church for the whole city and region for people from any background and walk of life. Alpha very much helps us begin to form this sort of community.

In September 2016, Revd Olly Ryder led a team to plant St Matthias Church Plymouth, a city centre resource church. Olly was previously Vicar of St Mark’s Kensal Rise and a Curate at Holy Trinity Brompton.

Story: Steve Whittington

Nearly 10 years ago, we decided to take a step out of our comfort zone, moving to a completely new city to plant a new church.

Very early on, we found that we started to create community around us and we needed a way of bringing people of faith and no faith together in a relaxed and informal environment. Our church in Teesside had grown to over 200 members and 100 of them had come to faith through going on Alpha and so, for us, there was no decision to be made – it had to be Alpha.

We decided to run a bit of a pilot and so we hired a room in a pub in the city centre and we invited everybody we knew, anybody we came into contact with, Christian or not, to do Alpha together.

The people of our city were used to gathering together for a meal, granted not usually with complete strangers, but it was an informal and friendly atmosphere and people loved it. From that initial pilot to the present day, we continue to run Alpha and over 300 people have now been on Alpha at Jubilee Hull.

Alpha is so easy to run, it's well resourced and you have everything you need at hand.

We don't have to scabble around for different materials, it's all in one place and it gives us complete confidence in what we are doing.



Running Alpha has shaped our church plant. It's encouraged the church to look outwards and to be more missional.

People don't feel the pressure of being "the traditional evangelist", instead they embrace the culture of invitation and invite those they know to try Alpha. It has brought people together who would never usually mix, from businessmen to those who have walked in off the streets. To anybody thinking about using Alpha as a church planting tool I would say go for it.

We have just planted again into the east of the city and we plan to use Alpha again. We sent the people who led Alpha to plant the new church. Alpha has been a brilliant training ground.

Running Alpha is a really effective way of raising up and releasing the next generation of Church Planters to reach different parts of our city and hopefully further afield. One thing I have learned is that Alpha cannot be an add on but it must be integral to everything we do. Every outreach event we hold, we invite people to come on Alpha. Everyone who comes through our debt advice centre, we invite to try Alpha.

So for us, we carry on, inviting new people, reaching out to those in our city who need the good news of Jesus and, as for Alpha, it will continue to be a core part of that mission that God has called us to.

In September 2006, Steve Whittington led a core team of people from Jubilee Church Teesside to plant Jubilee Church Hull.

Models for **Alpha** in a Church Plant

There are lots of ways to run Alpha and your model can change and develop over time. No two church plants are the same but there are a number of common approaches to using Alpha that work well with church planting.

Start with Alpha

1 Every church plant needs an evangelistic strategy and a simple strategy is to start with Alpha. Before you launch Sunday services and other activities you can run Alpha. Either as one big group, or in smaller groups that target different people. You can use

Alpha to set the culture of your plant and as a simple way to connect with new people.

Alpha Sunday

2 Running Alpha on Sunday is a great way of building up to launching a Sunday service. People are often free on Sunday and this is a good way to connect people with your intended meeting place. Hosting Alpha at a church venue can actually be a positive thing. It gets people across the threshold of the church venue and minimises the fears of going into a church building later on for other services and occasions.

Big Launch

3 Any Church Planter will want to do just a few things well. Alpha can act as a launch pad for a big-bang approach,

the “we’re launching this church for people like you, so come!” approach. Having a plan to run Alpha gives you something to invite people to, especially after natural opportunities like Christmas events or launch events.

Alpha as Small Groups

4 Alpha is a great fit for small groups that can run in homes or third spaces such as coffee shops and restaurants. From day one, every member of the team can be involved in mission by leading a small Alpha. A really straightforward pattern that has already been utilised in many church plants is to run Alpha, then begin a small group with those that came to faith, run Alpha again and create more small groups.





In 2016 we asked people around the globe to tell us about the impact Alpha has had in their church.



95%

95% Guests say that Alpha had a positive impact on their life.



93%

93% Alpha Leaders would recommend Alpha to another organisation.



81%

81% Guests on Alpha said that they felt the love of Jesus.

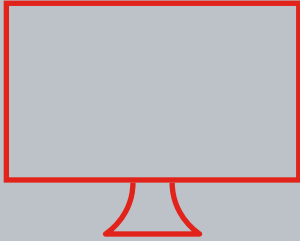


82%

82% Guests who would not have called themselves Christian before Alpha say they now call themselves a follower of Jesus.

Alpha Global Impact Study
Research carried out in 12 countries
by Barna in 2016

What Next?



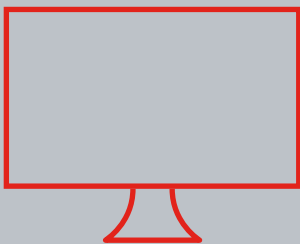
01

Log on to [Alpha Builder](#), register your Alpha for free and get access to resource previews and downloads.



02

Read [Alpha Basics](#), available for free on Alpha Builder.



03

Visit alpha.org/uk for news, stories and information on upcoming training events.

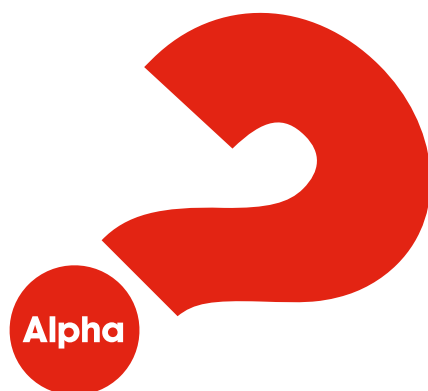
The Rt Revd Ric Thorpe
Bishop of Islington

Ric is the Anglican bishop responsible for starting new worshipping communities both within London and at a national level, serving as a resource for the whole Church of England.



“Alpha and church planting have a good history together. In all the church plants I have been involved with directly, Alpha has always been the primary tool for inviting guests to come and explore the good news about Jesus Christ. That’s because it works: it’s easy to invite people to; it’s format makes engagement accessible and enjoyable; and it enables people to encounter Jesus Christ personally.

It also helps the Church Planter to have at their fingertips a ready-made resource that doesn’t require a huge amount of preparation. And that is ideal for Church Planters who have so much to think about when they launch their plants. Most importantly, many people – in fact many of my friends – have come to Christ on Alpha and their lives have been turned around by him. And that still happens every day.”



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